15. Passing the Torch

Joe Root might look like a cherub, fresh-faced and innocent, but appearances can be deceptive. He left an indelible impression on me, in more ways than one, when he made his Yorkshire debut, against Essex, in a meaningless forty-over match at Headingley on the last day of the 2009 season.

We were a little hungover, after celebrating promotion from Division Two, but this small blond-haired kid cut through the fog. He later admitted to being ‘petrified’, and initially struggled to hit the ball off the square, but scored 63, as an opener, in a manner that suggested we had stumbled across a serious talent.

The great ones announce themselves. They make you sit up and take notice. The crispness of his ball striking, once he found his rhythm, made the same impact, in a completely different way, as the first time I saw Jos Buttler in a one-day innings. Joe’s black county kit looked loose, a little too big for him, but he had a presence, an authenticity. He had obviously been coached well; his technique was assured for a teenager. There was a correctness and precision about his batting. His style was reminiscent of Michael Vaughan, another England captain produced by the same club, Sheffield Collegiate. They followed the same pathway from Yorkshire Boys, and even used the same brand of bat and boots.

Joe also had the hard heart of a pro. He caught me at mid-off, dropped the ball, and still claimed it. I wasn’t particularly bothered about being given out, because there was nothing on the game. He eventually confessed,